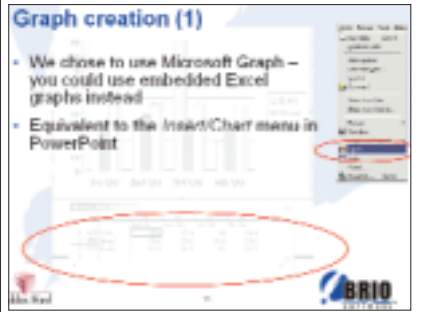
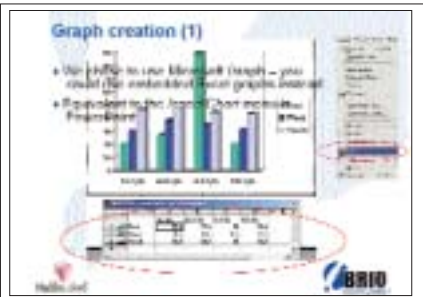
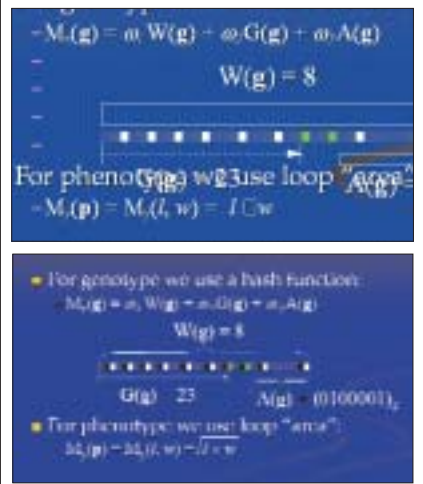


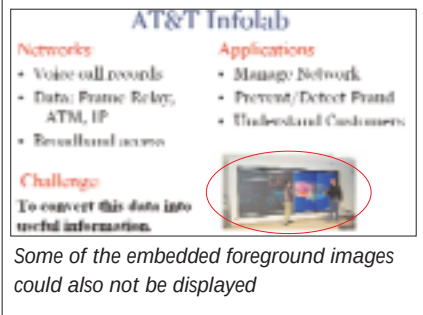
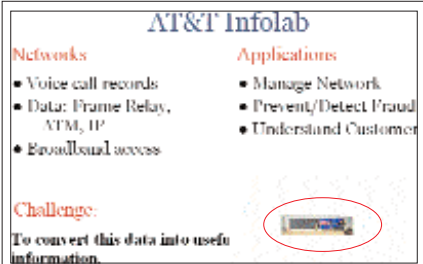


Freelance ScreenShow had problems displaying background images



While it generally had no problems with formulas, Freelance ScreenShow sometimes just couldn't get the layout right

transitions test file. While the colours were displayed properly, it could not display the contents of the slide. Some of the transitions, too, weren't displayed properly. One of the test files wasn't opened at



all, and Presentations gave an error message saying the file was corrupt; the same file was opened by the other office suites.

Some documents weren't imperfectly displayed, apparently because the conversion filters required to import the documents were unavailable, but we got the same errors even after complete installation of the software, with all the filters included.

Lotus Freelance ScreenShow

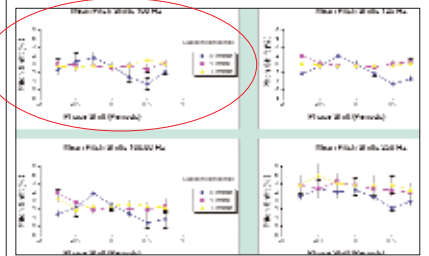
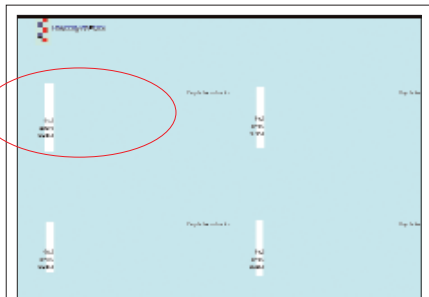
Not a great show!

Freelance ScreenShow had absolutely no problems with graphs, and displayed all of them perfectly. But it could not render transitions and slide effects properly. Some of the mathematical formulas were not displayed in their original form.

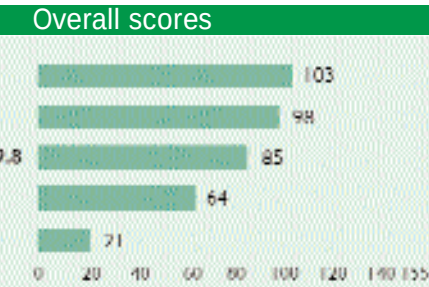
Conclusion

The level of compatibility offered by the alternative suites with MS Office documents varies widely. This even varies to great degrees amongst individual components of suites. These variations proved costly for the suite as a whole.

While Quattro Pro offered good compatibility with Excel files, the other components—WordPerfect and Presentations—



Some of the graphs, too, couldn't be displayed



brought the scores down. It managed an overall score of 64, and was fourth best. Ability Office, on the other hand, just didn't seem ready at all to handle our tests, consistently coming in last in all the tests. Ability ended up with a pathetic overall score of 21.

While Lotus SmartSuite 9.8 topped the spreadsheet and word processor tests, it was foiled in the presentation test, coming in last. Lotus SmartSuite finished third overall, with a score of 85.

OpenOffice.org 1.1 and Star Office 7 were the only two real contenders to the title, and as expected, took the top two spots. OpenOffice.org was impressive, and managed to tie with Star Office in the word processor and spreadsheet tests. Star Office made a late dash for the finish in the presentation test, beating OpenOffice.org by 5 points to end up with a decent overall score of 103. Unlike Star Office, OpenOffice.org is completely free, and made a very commendable effort.

In the end, we decided that Star Office 7 was indeed the best suite as a whole, and is the best Microsoft Office replacement out of the lot.

PAVEEN KURUP

